

## NEGATIVE AND POSITIVE COGNITIONS

Clinicians may find it useful to offer clients the list of sample negative and positive cognitions on this page. Generally, clients can make an appropriate selection or use the examples as a starting point to construct choices more suitable to their particular problems. The grouping into Responsibility/Defectiveness, Responsibility: Action, Safety/Vulnerability, and Power/Control/Choice may be helpful for the initial selection. However, there are nuances to many of the cognitions, whereby they overlap or are a combination of two or more categories. The selection should be one that resonates most for the individual, one that articulates the dysfunctional affect that pervades the person when he or she thinks of the event.

## EXAMPLES OF NEGATIVE AND POSITIVE COGNITIONS

| Negative Cognitions                                                                      | Positive Cognitions             |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| <b>Responsibility/Defectiveness</b>                                                      |                                 |
| I'm not good enough                                                                      | I am good enough/fine as I am   |
| I don't deserve love                                                                     | I deserve love; I can have love |
| I am a bad person                                                                        | I am a good (loving) person     |
| I am incompetent                                                                         | I am competent                  |
| I am worthless/inadequate                                                                | I am worthy; I am worthwhile    |
| I am shameful                                                                            | I am honorable                  |
| I am not lovable                                                                         | I am lovable                    |
| I deserve only bad things                                                                | I deserve good things           |
| I am permanently damaged                                                                 | I am/can be healthy             |
| I am ugly/my body is hateful                                                             | I am fine/attractive/lovable    |
| I do not deserve . . .                                                                   | I can have/deserve . . .        |
| I am stupid/not smart enough                                                             | I am intelligent/able to learn  |
| I am insignificant/unimportant                                                           | I am significant/important      |
| I am a disappointment                                                                    | I am OK just the way I am       |
| I deserve to die                                                                         | I deserve to live               |
| I deserve to be miserable                                                                | I deserve to be happy           |
| I am different/don't belong                                                              | I am OK as I am                 |
| I have to be perfect (out of inadequacy)                                                 | I am fine the way I am          |
| <b>Responsibility: Action</b>                                                            |                                 |
| I should have done something*                                                            | I did the best I could          |
| I did something wrong*                                                                   | I learned/can learn from it     |
| I should have known better*                                                              | I do the best I can/I can learn |
| *What does this say about you?<br>(e.g., I am shameful/I am stupid/I am<br>a bad person) | I'm fine as I am                |
| I am inadequate/weak                                                                     | I am adequate/strong            |

## Negative Cognitions

## Positive Cognitions

**Safety/Vulnerability**

I cannot trust anyone  
 I cannot protect myself  
 I am in danger  
 I am not safe  
 I am going to die  
 It's not OK (safe) to feel/show my emotions

I can choose whom to trust  
 I can learn to protect myself  
 It's over; I am safe now  
 I am safe now  
 I am safe now  
 I can safely feel/show my emotions

**Power/Control/Choice**

I am not in control  
 I am powerless/helpless  
 I cannot get what I want  
 I cannot stand up for myself  
 I cannot let it out  
 I cannot be trusted  
 I cannot trust myself  
 I cannot trust my judgment  
 I cannot succeed  
 I have to be perfect  
 I can't handle it

I am now in control  
 I now have choices  
 I can get what I want  
 I can make my needs known  
 I can choose to let it out  
 I can be trusted  
 I can/learn to trust myself  
 I can trust my judgment  
 I can succeed  
 I can be myself/make mistakes  
 I can handle it